Nehru at his core was an advocate of moderate change in social life, often legalistic and formalistic in his approach; Mao at his core was a champion of radical change and far more strategic and pragmatic. It is hard to ignore these basic ideological differences in understanding their quite opposite approaches to the border negotiations.

Tibet

While conflicts over the border were fundamental to the India–China quarrel, the status of Tibet too was fundamental. As with the border, so also on Tibet, the two sides began with a cooperative attitude. Between 1950 and 1954, Delhi and Beijing came to agree on the status of the province (technically, Autonomous Region). All should have been well, from this positive beginning. Instead, over the next five years, both countries concluded that the other side was failing to honour the understandings worked out on Tibet. Garver's careful archival research on China's decision to go to war in 1962 goes so far as to argue that Tibet was the *casus belli*, the reason for war.[53]

Accommodation

When the communists came to power, they made clear that they would integrate Tibet in China. In 1950, as they consolidated their hold, they moved their troops into the region. Nehru had no great love for the lama system in Tibet, seeing it as feudalistic and oppressive of ordinary Tibetans. At the same time, he was mindful of India's cultural and historical links with the province. Under the British, Delhi had enjoyed a quasi-diplomatic presence there as well. India also traded with Tibet. Indeed, most of Tibet's foodgrains and other consumer products came from India, the transport links to China being difficult over vast distances. Indian public opinion was outraged at China's moves against Tibet in 1950, but the government was